Singh, had attended. When he returned, he said the Eastern Army Commander sitting in Lucknow had no first-hand knowledge of the area and had based his appreciation and suggestions based on maps. He wasn't too impressed by Thorat's penchant for making sweeping predictions. He felt Thorat loved playing God. It used to rub a lot of senior officers the wrong way.'

Thorat's biggest blunder may have been to include Tawang in his defensive line. Interestingly, Palit claims that in his report to Army HQ submitted shortly after 4 Division arrived in NEFA from Punjab at the end of 1959, he had pointed out the tactical inadvisability of trying to hold Tawang. He says: 'After my reconnaissance of the Dirang Dzong Valley and the Tawang Salient, I concluded that the key tactical feature in Western Kameng [the vital ground in army jargon] was not Tawang but the spine of the commanding range stretching from Bomdila to Manda-la. In contrast, Tawang was located on the middle of the Bum-la massif, not on a commanding crest line. Furthermore, there were tracks from Bum-la that bypassed the township and went directly to Jang and Se-la; an invading enemy could easily bypass Tawang. In my opinion these tactical deficiencies made Tawang an unsuitable site for the main defensive position.'

In his subsequent report to Army HQ, Palit was to suggest that: 'For the defence of Kameng FD the "vital ground" was the ridge Bomdila-Manda-la and this was where I intended to arrange the major part of my force. For the defence of Tawang [a subsidiary task] I was prepared to detach one battalion; but to locate the greater part of my force in the Tawang salient, across the Se-la massif, would only invite the Chinese to bypass my position, occupy central Kameng and move down to the plains. Thus, by concentrating my force in Tawang, though I might succeed in my subsidiary task, my main aim—that is, defence of Kameng FD and thus guarding the routes [through it] to the plains—would be jeopardized.'

Palit's assessment, submitted to Army HQ around the time Thorat was beginning to articulate his views on the defensive line, was also faulty. The brigade commander had completely missed the Se-la feature that logically should have been the second line of defence in the sector. At the time, Palit says he dismissed the concept of siting brigade defences at heights over 13,500 feet as being impracticable. Thorat, on the other hand, by recommending Tawang as the second-tier defensive line was violating his